



The Selling Process

You may have great products or services, but you still have to sell them. To do this, you will need to understand the selling process and know how to build relationships with customers to generate further sales.

Understanding sales channels

There are many routes, or channels, to bring goods and services to market so that consumers can buy them. These sales channels range from online and retail to selling direct to the customer and selling through a third party. Before deciding what channel is right for your business, reflect on what makes people buy your type of product or service and where they buy them from. Consider the qualities of your product or service. Are customers more likely to buy your product if they can see and feel it? Is yours the type of service people can buy online, such as producing illustrations?

Whatever the approach, there are basic principles to follow when you are selling. Know your audience and speak to them in a way that they can relate to. If you are selling a piece of technology to people who are not technically proficient, use words they will understand. If you are selling face-to-face, do not describe at length why your offering is so good. Listen to your customer and let them know that their opinions matter.



BE AWARE

- › **Thinking about price** is one of the most important factors when selling. Find out what your customers really value, and be prepared to adjust your price.
- › **Pay attention to your existing customers** for they are your best prospects for future sales.
- › **Tailor what you say** to different types of customers, based on their individual buying behavior. Do not use the same message for everyone.
- › **Beware of not listening enough** to your customers. Your business will benefit from what they tell you.

Fulfilling orders

Once you have made a sale you need to fulfil the order. Think about your customers' expectations, such as when they will expect to receive their order, and make the process straightforward. You may decide to take orders and despatch the goods yourself. However, as your business grows, you may want to outsource this task to a third party, such as an e-fulfilment company (see pp.74–75).

The sales funnel

A good way of thinking about the selling process is imagining it as a funnel—one that shows the stages prospective customers go through before making a purchase, each step bringing them closer to becoming a customer. At the top of the funnel, there is a large number of prospective customers, but these become fewer and fewer as you descend through the funnel to the people who actually buy your goods. Your job is to make sure there are enough customers in the funnel to generate sufficient sales for your business.

“We exist as businesses to serve our customers and they are always right.”

Manish Chopra, CEO of Little